Electric Charge

Exam code: 0625 & 0972

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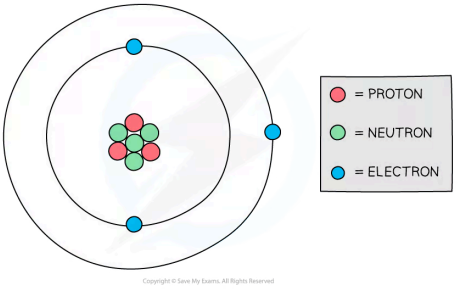
Positive & negative charges

- There are two types of electric charge: **positive** and **negative**
- Inside an atom, there are
  - negatively charged **electrons**
  - positively charged **protons**
  - neutral (no charge) **neutrons**
- Atoms contain equal numbers of protons and electrons as they have equal and opposite charges
- These charges cancel out so the overall charge of an atom is zero

Structure of an atom



The number of negative electrons in an atom balances the number of positive protons

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a **force** on each other, this could be:
  - **Attractive** (the objects get closer together)
  - **Repulsive** (the objects move further apart)

Electric forces between charges

Opposite charges attract, like charges repel

- Whether two objects attract or repel depends on their **charge**
  - If the charges are the **opposite**, they will **attract**
  - If the charges are the **same**, they will **repel**

Attraction or repulsion summary table

Charge of object 1	Charge of object 2	Attract or repel?
positive	positive	repel
positive	negative	attract
negative	positive	attract
negative	negative	repel

- The table shows that:
  - Positive charges **repel** other positive charges and **attract** negative charges
  - Negative charges **repel** other negative charges and **attract** positive charges

Extended tier only

- Electric charge is measured in units called **coulombs (C)**

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Remember the saying "**opposites attract**" when answering questions about forces between charged particles.

While electrostatic forces share many similarities with magnetic forces, they are different phenomena **– do not confuse the two!**

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